

Section 0

Referral Memorandum

Version 2.0 — Preliminary Draft

Petitioner: Ashley Marie Meredith, MSN | Pro Se

■ PRELIMINARY DRAFT — NOT FOR CITATION OR DISTRIBUTION WITHOUT PERMISSION

PETITION TO AUDIT — IOWA DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

CHILD WELFARE SYSTEMS — SECTION 0

SECTION 0 — REFERRAL & REQUEST FOR REVIEW

Version 1.1 | June 5, 2026

Audit Petition Packet v2.0 (5/2026)

PURPOSE: This section establishes the formal submission basis and procedural trigger for this petition. It contains the referral memorandum, requested audit actions, the legal and procedural authority basis, a high-level scope statement, a signpost to the interpretive framework, and document control information. Analytical content begins in Section 1. Interpretive framework definitions are in Section 2.

0.1 REFERRAL MEMORANDUM

TO: Rob Sand, Iowa Auditor of State

Iowa Office of Auditor of State

State Capitol Building, Room 111

Des Moines, Iowa 50319

FROM: Ashley Marie Meredith, MSN

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DATE: June 2026

SUBJECT: Citizen Petition for Audit — Iowa Department of Health and Human Services Child Welfare Systems (Including All Legacy Iowa Department of Human Services Functions)

RE: Iowa Code § 11.6(3); Iowa Code § 11.24

1. NATURE OF THIS SUBMISSION

This memorandum and the enclosed petition packet formally request that the Iowa Auditor of State initiate a performance, compliance, and financial audit of the Iowa Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) child welfare systems, including all legacy Iowa Department of Human Services (DHS) child welfare, child protection, foster care, adoption, guardianship, and family services functions and all funding streams, contracts, data systems, and corrective action records maintained before or after the July 1, 2022 administrative reorganization.

This submission is made pursuant to Iowa Code § 11.6(3), which authorizes citizen-initiated audit applications, and Iowa Code § 11.24, which grants the Auditor of State discretionary authority to examine any officer or department of the state. Federal funds oversight authority attaches independently under the state's obligations as the administering agency for Title IV-E, Title IV-B, CAPTA, and related federal child welfare programs.

2. PETITIONER IDENTITY AND STANDING

Ashley Marie Meredith, MSN, is a resident of Benton County, Iowa. She is the biological mother of children who were involved with the Iowa child welfare system and whose case history is documented in

Section 16 of this petition as contemporaneous evidence of active systemic conditions. She submits this petition as a citizen under Iowa Code § 11.6(3) and not in her capacity as a party to any pending legal proceeding.

The personal case evidence in this petition is included solely as

contemporaneous documentation of system conditions documented independently by federal reviews, state audits, and Ombudsman investigations. It is not submitted as a claim for individual relief. Section 16 contains the scope limitation statement governing that material.

3. BASIS FOR THIS REQUEST

Documentation enclosed with this petition indicates potential control deficiencies across multiple functional areas of Iowa HHS child welfare administration:

FEDERAL OVERSIGHT RECORD: Iowa has failed to achieve substantial conformity with federal CFSR outcomes across three consecutive review cycles (2003, 2010, 2018). The same deficiencies recur across all three cycles. The Round 3 Program Improvement Plan was submitted four times and was never formally approved. [A02,

A03, A04]

FINANCIAL CONTROLS: Iowa Auditor of State reports spanning 2009–2025 document questioned costs, subrecipient monitoring failures, and contract enforcement gaps. \$167,716 in questioned federal costs was documented as recently as November 2025. [A23,

A24, A25, A26]

DATA INTEGRITY AND DOCUMENTATION: Iowa's own compliance documents acknowledge a "high risk of inaccurate data" and characterize key safety metrics as "not available" due to system limitations. Federal court monitors have classified behavioral health data as "not reliable." DOJ findings document records that are overwritable without an audit trail. [A06, A07, A09, A10]

MONITORING AND OVERSIGHT: Three child fatalities in state-monitored placements produced three Ombudsman investigations documenting the same intake triage, supervisory, and monitoring failures across a 17-year span. The most recent documented active harm in a licensed placement (Drew household, March 2021–October 2023) is not accompanied by any identified monitoring escalation in the public record. [A28, A29, A30, A33]

REPEAT FINDINGS WITHOUT SUSTAINED CORRECTION: Deficiencies identified in federal CFSR rounds have been documented in subsequent rounds without evidence of durable correction. The same pattern is documented in AOS reports, independent evaluations, and Ombudsman investigations issued over the same period. [A02–A04,

A23–A26, A27–A30]

CCWIS DATA SYSTEM: Iowa's new child welfare data system is under construction under a \$41.9M contract with Google/Carahsoft (March 2026). The contract lacks background check requirements for contractor personnel accessing child welfare PHI. Federal IAPD approval was conditional, not unconditional. [A44, A45]

4. ADMINISTRATIVE CHANNELS EXHAUSTED

Prior to this petition, the following channels were pursued without producing a systemic corrective response:

Iowa Open Records Requests #26-927 and #26-1536 (February 25, 2026). Responses produced with delays and partial productions documented in communication logs. [A42A–A42D]

Direct inquiry to Iowa HHS regarding CCWIS data governance. No substantive response documented.

Formal inquiry to the Iowa Office of Citizens' Aide / Ombudsman (May 30, 2026). Response pending at time of petition submission.

Congressional engagement: Senator Chuck Grassley's office (Garrett Arbuckle) contacted petitioner May 15, 2026 following petitioner's outreach regarding CFSR Round 4 structural concerns. Staff meeting conducted May 27, 2026. Senator Grassley responded directly May 19, 2026. [A57, pending receipt of call record]

The petition to the Auditor of State under Iowa Code § 11.6(3) is the appropriate next administrative channel.

0.2 REQUESTED ACTIONS FOR OVERSIGHT REVIEW

The following audit actions are formally requested. Full corrective action specifications are contained in Section 19 of this petition.

ACTION 1 — PERFORMANCE AUDIT

Examine whether Iowa HHS child welfare programs have achieved required performance outcomes under the federal CFSR framework across completed review cycles, and whether corrective action plans implemented pursuant to those cycles produced measurable, sustained improvement verifiable in subsequent reviews.

ACTION 2 — FINANCIAL AND COMPLIANCE AUDIT

Examine Iowa HHS child welfare financial controls, including:

- (a) Title IV-E and Title IV-B claiming accuracy and compliance
- (b) Contract monitoring and subrecipient oversight
- (c) Federal grant administration and expenditure traceability
- (d) The \$41.9M Google/Carahsoft CCWIS contract — procurement compliance, PHI access controls, and IV-E reimbursability

ACTION 3 — DATA SYSTEMS AND AUDITABILITY REVIEW

Assess whether Iowa HHS data systems — including legacy FACS/SACWIS and the CCWIS procurement — meet applicable federal and state standards for data integrity, audit trail reliability, and PHI access governance.

ACTION 4 — CORRECTIVE ACTION ACCOUNTABILITY REVIEW

Evaluate whether the three Program Improvement Plans submitted across CFSR Rounds 1–3 (a) addressed the documented root causes of non-conformity, (b) produced implementation evidence sufficient to verify strategy execution, and (c) resulted in durable practice change that carried forward into subsequent review cycles.

ACTION 5 — FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

Issue findings and recommendations under Iowa Code § 11.24 and applicable GAGAS standards. Petitioner requests notice of initiation or declination consistent with Iowa Code § 11.6(3).

0.3 BASIS FOR REFERRAL — LEGAL AND PROCEDURAL AUTHORITY

IOWA CODE § 11.6(3) — CITIZEN-INITIATED AUDIT APPLICATION

Iowa Code § 11.6(3) authorizes any citizen to submit to the Auditor of State a written application requesting examination or audit of a state department or officer. This petition constitutes that application. The petitioner is an Iowa resident and satisfies the citizen standing requirement.

Iowa Code § 11.6(3) creates a procedural right: a qualifying citizen application must be received and considered by the Auditor of State. That right is distinct from — and does not limit — the Auditor's discretionary authority under § 11.24 regarding whether, when, and in what form to conduct any examination. This petition invokes both provisions: § 11.6(3) as the procedural basis for submission and mandatory consideration, and § 11.24 as the substantive authority for the scope of review requested.

IOWA CODE § 11.24 — DISCRETIONARY AUDIT AUTHORITY

Iowa Code § 11.24 grants the Auditor of State authority to examine, at the Auditor's discretion, the accounts of any officer or department of the state. This authority is independent of and supplemental to the § 11.6(3) citizen application process.

GAGAS — GENERALLY ACCEPTED GOVERNMENT AUDITING STANDARDS

This petition is structured and documented in conformity with the Government Accountability Office's Government Auditing Standards (GAGAS, 2018 Revision), specifically:

- Chapter 1 (government audit purpose and authority)
- Chapter 6 (performance audit standards — evidence sufficiency)
- Chapter 7 (financial audit standards — internal control and compliance)

The GAGAS framework governs the evidentiary classification, sourcing methodology, and assertion standards applied throughout this petition (see Section 5 — Analytical Framework).

FEDERAL FUNDS OVERSIGHT

Iowa HHS administers federal child welfare funds under Title IV-E (Foster Care and Adoption Assistance), Title IV-B (Child and Family Services), and CAPTA (Child Abuse Prevention and Treatment Act).

Administration of federal funds subjects Iowa HHS to both state audit authority and the requirements of the Single Audit Act (31 U.S.C. § 7501 et seq.) and applicable OMB Uniform Guidance (2 C.F.R. Part 200). Deficiencies in financial controls, contract oversight, and data integrity documented in this petition implicate those obligations.

ICWA — INDIAN CHILD WELFARE ACT

ICWA compliance requirements (25 U.S.C. § 1901 et seq.), including active efforts, tribal notification, and qualified expert witness standards, are documented as deficiencies in the federal CFSR record. ICWA non-compliance constitutes an independent basis for federal and state audit review. [A02, A09]

2022 REORGANIZATION — CONTINUITY OF JURISDICTION

The July 1, 2022 administrative consolidation of the Iowa Department of Human Services into Iowa HHS was an administrative restructuring. It did not extinguish audit jurisdiction over legacy DHS records, funding streams, contracts, or corrective action obligations. Iowa HHS is the legal successor entity for all purposes relevant to this petition. Records, contracts, and compliance obligations that originated under DHS remain subject to audit review under Iowa Code § 11.

0.4 SCOPE OF SUBMISSION — HIGH-LEVEL OVERVIEW

SUBJECT MATTER: Iowa HHS child welfare functions, including child protection, foster care, guardianship, adoption, family services, contracted provider oversight, decision-support tools, funding streams, records systems, and corrective actions, whether maintained under the former Iowa DHS or the current Iowa HHS.

REVIEW PERIOD: From the earliest documented oversight materials through the date of this submission, with emphasis on:

- Federal CFSR review cycles 1–3 (2003–2019) and the active Round 4 (2025–present)
- AOS findings spanning 2009–2025

— Ombudsman fatality investigations (2000–2020)

— CCWIS procurement (2025–2026)

EVIDENTIARY BASIS: 49 primary source attachments organized in Sections 6–16, plus two companion analytical reports filed concurrently with this petition:

Companion Document 1: Iowa Child Welfare Systems Review — CFSR Longitudinal Forensic Analysis and Round 4 Structural Integrity Assessment

Companion Document 2: Iowa CCWIS Procurement and Data Governance Review

ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK: Eight audit domains (A–H) and thirteen deficiency categories (F1–F13), defined in Section 5. Domains and deficiency categories are applied consistently across all sections of this petition. Full definitions and counting methodology are in Section 5.

WHAT THIS SUBMISSION DOES NOT ASSERT: This petition does not assert claims against individual caseworkers, judges, or service providers.

It does not seek to relitigate individual custody or termination proceedings. It is a formal inquiry into whether Iowa HHS's institutional control environment — financial controls, contract monitoring, data systems, corrective action mechanisms — meets applicable standards. Where individual case evidence appears (Sections 14–16), it is included as contemporaneous documentation of active systemic conditions, not as individual grievance. Section 16 contains the governing scope limitation statement.

0.5 READER GUIDANCE NOTICE

For interpretive framework definitions — including domain descriptions, deficiency category classifications, evidentiary status standards, and assertion-level guidance — see Section 2.6.

0.6 DOCUMENT CONTROL INFORMATION

Petition Title: Petition to Audit — Iowa Department of Health and Human Services Child Welfare Systems

Petitioner: Ashley Marie Meredith, MSN

Version: Audit Petition Packet v2.0 (5/2026)

Date of Current

Version: June 2026

Statutory Basis: Iowa Code § 11.6(3); Iowa Code § 11.24

Target Entity: Iowa Department of Health and Human Services,
including all legacy Iowa DHS child welfare
functions

Companion

Documents: CFSR Companion Report v1.0 (May 30, 2026)

CCWIS Companion Report v1.0 (filed concurrently)

Total Primary

Attachments: 49 (A01–A30; A33–A52); plus sub-groups
A42A–A42D; A57 pending

Pending Items: A57 (Grassley call record — pending receipt)

Ombudsman response — pending; to be indexed
on receipt

Signature Pages: Filed with this petition under separate tab

[A42 — Online Petition; physical signature pages
filed under cover]

Total Pages: [To be completed at final production]

AI Disclosure: AI assistance was used materially in the
preparation of this document. That assistance
does not constitute independent verification
of any factual claim. See Section 5.8.

0.7 REVISION HISTORY

This table documents the structural and evidentiary development of the
petition packet from initial conception through the current version.

It is a factual provenance record derived from the working document
archive, contemporaneous file metadata, and the digital drafting log.

Pre-digital working materials (early concept drafts, handwritten notes,

■ ■ ■ date — both appear fully formed in the March 26 NotebookLM output. ■

■ v1.6 ■ March 17– ■ ChatGPT "Petition to Audit" custom GPT project initiated (March 17, ■
 ■ ■ April 2026 ■ 2026). Attachment count expanded from 27 to 38. Fatality Risk Analysis ■
 ■ ■ ■ and Systemic Failure Matrix drafted (later reclassified to Section 13 ■
 ■ ■ ■ body in v2.2). Cover page metadata standardized. PPRCP (Post- ■
 ■ ■ ■ Permanency Risk Convergence Profile) framework developed as original ■
 ■ ■ ■ analytical lens. "Trinity Pattern" framing introduced (removed in v2.0 ■
 ■ ■ ■ remediation as advocacy-register language). Domain crosswalk table ■
 ■ ■ ■ added to Evidentiary Index. Legislative brief for Senator Ernst drafted. ■

■ v1.7–v1.8 ■ April 7–29, 2026 ■ Five dedicated NotebookLM analytical sessions produced the core ■
 ■ ■ ■ evidentiary architecture: seven-step Comprehensive Attachment Analysis ■
 ■ ■ ■ System (CAS); F1–F13 deficiency category framework applied to all ■
 ■ ■ ■ source documents; "Chronicity of Non-Conformity" and "Compliance ■
 ■ ■ ■ Decay" patterns formally named; three-layer evidence model ■
 ■ ■ ■ (Evidence/Finding/Interpretation) operationalized; longitudinal ■
 ■ ■ ■ performance chart completed (R1–R3); "Data Validity Gap" formally ■
 ■ ■ ■ characterized; "Standing-Based Information Blackout" developed; ■
 ■ ■ ■ media evidentiary framework (7-step) finalized; CFSR Round 4 ■
 ■ ■ ■ Structural Integrity Analysis produced with verdict: "structurally ■
 ■ ■ ■ incapable of producing a truthful assessment." Sources across these ■
 ■ ■ ■ sessions totaled 220+ documents. Named studio outputs included: ■
 ■ ■ ■ "The Chronicity of Non-Conformity," "The JARVIS Deficit," "Iowa's ■
 ■ ■ ■ Shadow System," and "Iowa HHS Systemic Risk Analysis 2003–2026." ■

■ Apr 14–15, ■ April 14–15, ■ ANALYTICAL PIVOT — First formal application of the audit packet to ■
 ■ 2026 ■ 2026 ■ the petitioner's individual case. Perplexity AI session ("Iowa HHS ■
 ■ (Perplexity) ■ ■ Child Welfare Audit Petition and Risk Assessment," 2 sources, April 14) ■
 ■ ■ ■ produced the first cross-application of audit findings to a motion to ■
 ■ ■ ■ vacate TPR framework. Key outputs: (1) "Repeated documentation reuse" ■
 ■ ■ ■ formally identified as the official CFSR term for the petitioner's ■
 ■ ■ ■ own documented "copy and paste" assessments — establishing direct ■

■■■ SOURCING: ORR attributions corrected — A44–A50 assigned to #26-1536 (not ■■■ #26-927). A54 (Comm. 626) located independently via Iowa HHS public website ■■■ (February 2026) and inserted into Section 9. Companion report provenance ■■■ context added. SECTIONS DRAFTED: S5–S13, S18, S19, CFSR Companion v1.0, ■■■ CCWIS Companion v1.0. ■■

■ v2.0 style ■ May 30–31, 2026 ■ Style Guide v2.0 finalized (May 30, 2026). Locked: double rule (thick + thin) ■

■ & arch. ■ ■ signature design element; three-tier document hierarchy (Section / Part / ■
 ■ ■ ■ Attachment); "Obtained Via" provenance field on attachment cover pages; muted ■
 ■ ■ ■ four-color palette; running header and footer standards; prohibition on body-page ■
 ■ ■ ■ repetition of cover-page metadata. Master TOC v2.2 finalized. Section 13 ■
 ■ ■ ■ three-layer structure locked (PPRCP / Fatality Risk Analysis / Systemic Failure ■
 ■ ■ ■ Matrix — all body content). Google Drive folder structure created (21 subfolders, ■
 ■ ■ ■ SECTION 00 through SECTION 20). ■

■ v2.1 ■ May 27–June 4, ■ S14–S17 drafted (Drew household offense timeline; systemic impact / media ■
 ■ ■ 2026 ■ corroboration; exhaustion-of-channels; stakeholder engagement). A33 body pages ■
 ■ ■ ■ drafted (30-month monitoring gap). Cover sheets A33–A38 finalized with verified ■
 ■ ■ ■ URLs. Amanda Buckingham/Tweedy materials analyzed; two-affidavit strategy ■
 ■ ■ ■ established; A41 designated for Tweedy correspondence (Nathan Repp / Washington ■
 ■ ■ ■ County Attorney). 10 standing instructions codified (affidavit scope; media ■
 ■ ■ ■ corroboration; petitioner-synthesized matrix classification; personal case ■
 ■ ■ ■ evidence segregation; Section 0.5 scope limit; sworn limitation clause; ■
 ■ ■ ■ excerpted attachment rule). All 15 drafted sections uploaded to Google Drive. ■

■ v2.2 ■ June 4–5, 2026 ■ GAGAS document classification framework locked and codified in Project Bible

■ ■ ■ A05 → S7 body; A31 → S13 body; A32 → S13 body; A53 → Companion Doc 2. ■

■ ■ ■ verbatim extract + full source citation + zero petitioner analysis = valid A##. ■

■ ■ ■ All 14 drafted sections (S5–S19) audited and corrected: deficiency category ■

■ ■ ■ terminology; domain label format (letter + full name); footer version date ■
■ ■ ■ standardized to (5/2026); cross-references; AI disclosure; companion report ■
■ ■ ■ pointer. ■

■ ■ ■ v2.3 ■ June 5, 2026 ■ Attachment metadata v2.3 CSV finalized (expanded to A1–A56). Additions:
A44–A50 ■

■ ■ ■ (CCWIS/ORR — IAPD, Google/Carahsoft contract, CB approval, three policies); ■
■ ■ ■ A51–A52 (OCIO IT Standards, HHS Open Records Policy); A54 (Comm. 626); A55 ■
■ ■ ■ (Buckingham Affidavit placeholder); A56 (Ombudsman Inquiry Letter). A08 ■
■ ■ ■ restored (Historical Litigation & Reform Efforts). Section 9 numbering ■
■ ■ ■ corrected (off-by-one error from v2.2). Companion report architecture ■
■ ■ ■ formalized. All section drafts uploaded to Google Drive. ■

■ ■ ■ v2.4 ■ June 5, 2026 ■ CURRENT VERSION. A54–A56 retired to vacatur file. A05, A31, A32 formally ■
■ (current) ■ ■ reclassified as body content. A53 → Companion Document 2 (no A## number). ■
■ ■ ■ Clean attachment range locked: A01–A30, A33–A52 (49 primary attachments). ■
■ ■ ■ v2.4 CSV finalized (103 rows). Sections drafted this version: S0 (Referral & ■
■ ■ ■ Request for Review); S1 (Executive Synthesis, v1.1); S4 (System Timeline). ■
■ ■ ■ Drive folders SECTION_00 and SECTION_04 renamed to match architecture. ■
■ ■ ■ Congressional engagement (Grassley call, May 27, 2026) documented; A57 ■
■ ■ ■ reserved pending receipt of call record. ■

■ ■ ■ PENDING ■ [Final ■ Flash drive pre-digital materials to be reviewed; pre-v1.0 entries to be ■
■ ■ ■ production] ■ refined when available. Total page count to be completed at final production. ■
■ ■ ■ A57 (Grassley call record) to be indexed on receipt. A58 (Ombudsman response) ■
■ ■ ■ to be indexed on receipt. Signature pages to be integrated. Section 20 ■
■ ■ ■ (Certification) execution date to be completed. Final pre-submission checklist ■
■ ■ ■ to be cleared. ■

AI assistance was used materially in the preparation of this document. That assistance does not constitute independent verification of any factual claim.